Elephant's Graveyard

By George Brant

HUNGRY TOWNSPERSON: **(Pg 10)** It was September and there was a Town . . . Erwin, Tennessee

ENGINEER: It was September and there was a Town and a Circus

RINGMASTER: Sparks World Famous Shows Proudly Presents . . .

YOUNG TOWNSPERSON: an Elephant . . . Mary . . . **(Pg 15)** We dreamed her before we saw her.

TOWNSPEOPLE: **(Pg 16)** Mary! Mary! Mary!

MUDDY TOWNSPERSON: **(Pg 15)** She was plastered on every telephone pole.

RINGMASTER: **(Pg 16)** Ladies and Gentlemen, Children of All Ages!

STRONGMAN: Proudly present a tremendous exhibition of wealth and splendor

CLOWN: All new for 1916.

TRAINER: Starring Mary: the largest living land animal on Earth.

YOUNG TOUNSPERSON: **(Pg 15)** The Circus was coming!

TOWNSPEOPLE: **(Pg 16)** Mary! Mary! Mary! *(beat)*

TOUR MANAGER: **(Pg 10)** And there was as Man with Red Hair. *(A train whistle)*

INTRODUCTION

Her nickname, "Big Mary," came well-earned. Touted as "The Largest Living Land Animal On Earth," the five-ton elephant stood taller than the popular Barnum & Bailey's star, Jumbo, hovering over him by a supposed three inches. Playing musical instruments, standing on her head, and even catching baseballs, this gentle giant awed crowds all over the country. Mary's future would find an expiration date, however, when the circus made its way to Tennessee.

Based on true events . . . Elephant's Graveyard by George Brant

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RINGMASTER: **(Pg 17)** An elephant is an investment. You've got the trained seals, the trapeze, the Strongman. Fine, but they aren't the bread and butter. No rubberneck comes to a circus doesn't have a big elephant.

TRAINER: They love a parade. All elephants do in the wild anyway. Wild elephant herd follows

the leader and the leader is the biggest female. So they all march behind Mary, one behind the other. Let me tell ya, only thing better than watchin' an elephant parade is being in the elephant parade. Sittin' on top of the world – on top of Mary, legs wrapped around her back, head in the clouds.

TOUR MANAGER: (Pg 18) They're not just for show. Hardest workers I got. Once that train stops in a town – they're mine. Get 'em to load and unload the boxcars, push up the tent poles. . . *(beat)* Tennessee started off with a bang. Circus can tell how it goes over by how many locals want to run away with it afterwards. Fifteen —That was a record.

CLOWN: (Pg 19) There was a Man with Red Hair

TOUR MANAGER: (Pg 20) Shocka red hair. Tells me he's good with animals. He says, I want to work with the elephants, I have to work with the elephants.

TRAINER: (Pg 21) Lou knocks on my car, tells me I got a new roommate. Goofy-lookin' red-haired guy. I show Red his corner. He gripes about the smell and I tell him get used to it. Townies think elephants smell bad in the ring, try sleepin' with one in a boxcar. He shuts up when he sees Mary, looks at her like she's the answer to his prayers.

TOUR MANAGER: We left Kingsport for Erwin. *(A train whistle)*

TRAINER: (Pg 24) I'd shown Red how to feed her, groom her, that's it. That's all he knew. One day. One day! What the hell can you learn in one day? In India, guy stays with an elephant his whole life, like a marriage. Here. . . Lou waltzed in—says . . .

TOUR MANAGER: (Pg 25) Shorty, he wants to ride Mary in the march. Back off and give the new guy a chance.

TRAINER: I shoulda said something. I shoulda told him she was mine. I didn't. Just stepped aside. Maybe made a face. That was my big protest, a face. *(beat)* It's trust. Trust you build up over years, not one day. Every peanut, every bath, every pat on the trunk. It's love. But Red didn't have time for any of that. *(beat)* TRUNKS UP! *(Circus music as the parade begins)*

YOUNG TOWNSPERSON: (Pg 26) That big elephant was leadin' the whole thing. That goofy guy – red hair? He was up on her back.

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TOWNSPEOPLE: Mary, Mary, Mary!

HUNGRY TOWNSPERSON: **(Pg 27-28)** A band was playin, people rushin' out, circus plowin' through the middle of town . . . Erwin Garbage Department on strike until further notice. Clean up your own junk, people of Erwin. We on strike. And thus, the Holy Grail of Garbage left in the mud: a juicy chunk of watermelon. That's when the dominoes start to fallin' Elephant see melon . . . walks toward [it].

Elephant rider encourages elephant to abandon melon – is most insistent. Elephant hook across [its] head. Breaks elephant hook across [its] tusk.

Elephant decides she's had enough – picks the rider off [its] back and throws [him] into a soda pop stand.

[Just when] the rider thinks it's over, the elephant walks over and puts [its] foot on [his] head. *(scream)* [And his] head explodes.

MUDDY TOWNSPERSON: **(Pg 29)** She stepped on his skull. Crushed it. *(beat)* Coulda been any of us.

MARSHAL: **(Pg 30)** It coulda ended there, but that wouldn'ta been right, that wouldn'ta been justice. It wasn't walking away from this. Erwin don't look kindly upon murderers.

TOUR MANAGER: **(Pg 31)** Tried to get in touch with Red's family, friends. Didn't have none.

TRAINER: Like he didn't exist except for us, like he was born to do nothin' but cause us trouble.

RINGMASTER: Still have a show to do that night. Must go on. DOORS!

TOUR MANAGER: I told Charlie, maybe we should keep Mary out, maybe the people'd forget. But he told me what I already knew:

RINGMASTER: They won't forget. Aren't coming to see the circus. Coming to see the killer. **(Pg 32)** Ladies and Gentlemen, Children of All Ages . . . Sparks World Famous Shows Proudly Presents . . .

TOUR MANAGER: Normal night we play up the danger, talk up the toothless tier. Not this time. Brought Mary out like she was the most innocent a' God's creatures. *(Drum roll / cymbal crash. A gasp)*

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TOWNSPEOPLE: (Pg 33) Kill it. Kill it. Kill it!

YOUNG TOWNSPERSON: It got louder . . .

TOWNSPEOPLE: Kill it. Kill it. Kill it!

YOUNG TOWNSPERSON: The marshal and people were wavin' guns around. Everybody shoutin'. All 'cept the colored section.

CLOWN: No, no, no! Red was one of us. Part of the circus. He knew the risks. You townies go no claim here. Military has its own court – so does the circus.

TRAINER: She was favoring her left tusk! They have nerves in there, big ones, run down half the tooth. You all saw him hittin' her tusk with the hook, whackin' the spit outta it, tryin' to get her to behave, to stay in line. What's she s'posed to do? She stopped him. That's all. She stopped him!

TOWNSPEOPLE: Kill it. Kill it. Kill it!

YOUNG TOWNSPERSON: (Pg 34) Fin'ly the Ringmaster raised his hand.

RINGMASTER: (Pg 35) *(hand raised)* Ladies and Gentlemen, Children of All Ages – the Circus Understands Your Wishes. Theis Mary Matter Will Be Settled to Your Liking Tomorrow . . . and We are Open to Suggestions.

ENGINEER: (Pg 36) They talked about electrocuting it, frying it like some of them had seen in the moving picture Thomas Edison made. But that was copycat stuff. (beat) The railyard. There's a crane there can lift 100 tons. Now, something like that could do something special, something never been done before. Something like that could hang her. Hang her like any other murderer.

MUDDY TOWNSPERSON: Eye for an eye. Erwin'll fin'ly be clean.

TRAINER: (Pg 37) (sadly) So now Lou and Sparks need my help. *(to the men)* I wasn't good enough to handle her while she was alive, but I'm good enough to help you kill her? *(beat)* I will never forgive you; *(to audience)* [but] I stay 'cause if I don't, they'll mess it up.

MUDDY TOWNSPERSON: (Pg 41-42) Mornin' fin'ly came. Got to the railroad tracks, saw men in the only suits they owned. Women in their Sunday best, prancin' 'round with parasols like it

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was Easter. People standin' top of boxcars, picknic baskets, punch. Laughin', dancin'. You could feel it – we were ready.

TRAINER: TRUNKS UP! *(marching drums)*

STEAM SHOVEL OPERATOR: The killer was in front. Them elephants marched out holdin' each other's tails with their trunks – like a parade.

TRAINER: **(Pg 37)** Tuskers aren't stupid, they know when somethin's up. You have to make her think it's a normal march. She can't go out there alone. Mary has to lead the parade, like it's any other parade.

STEAM SHOVEL OPERATOR: **(Pg 42)** They walked through the railyard up to the crane, and this guy chained the killer's foot to a train track.

TRAINER: *(calming Mary down)* It's okay, it's okay, it's okay. Ready? Showtime, sweetie.

STEAM SHOVEL OPERATOR: The guy hooked the chain 'round her neck, patted her back and stood up. *(applause)*

YOUNG TOWNSPERSON: She looked scary.

PREACHER: **(Pg 44)** Helpless.

STEAM SHOVEL OPERATOR: Confused.

MUDDY TOWNSPERSON: Guilty.

MARSHAL: Like a killer.

ENGINEER: The crane groaned, gears grindin and --- *(gasp)*

MUDDY TONSPERSON: It rose up steady till it was standin' on it's hind ligs, tiptoe. Toenails scrapin' the railroad track . . . like it was doin' a trick.

MARSHAL: **(Pg 45)** But then we started wonderin' why that thing wasn't goin' any higher up.

HUNGRY TOWNSPERSON: Nobody remembered to unhook her. Her foot was still chained to the track.

STEAM SHOVEL OPERATOR: They were rippin' her in half, pullin' her leg at this weird angle.

MUDDY TOWNSPERSON: Her leg broke – a bone 'bout as big as my whole body – breakin', I could feel it in my spine, my spine buckled, ached in sympathy, rang like a tuning fork.

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STEAM SHOVEL OPERATOR: Shoulda left then, I s'ose. But I stayed to see 'em unhook her foot, lift her up again –

PREACHER: **(Pg 46)** Think she was nearly gone, then. Or woulda been, soon. That is . . . if the chain hadn't broke.

YOUNG TOWNSPERSON: The chain popped and she came crashin' down onto the railroad track with this sound like an oak tree crackin' in half. That guy who climbed her before started screamin' like he was the one fell down. And they handed him a thicker link chain. And I couldn't believe it, but he hooked her up again.

MARSHAL: **(Pg 47)** Crane lifted it off its feet again – higher . . .

YOUNG TOWNSPERSON: Higher . . She made some noises, some . . . air just kinda puffed outta her trunk and then that . . . that was it. *(quiet)*

MUDDY TOWNSPERSON: *(with shock and sadness)* I let my breath out. I breathed in, lungs searchin' for that sanctified air. Waiting to be made clean. But the air . . . it tasted no different. It was flat and stale and rank.

MARSHAL: **(Pg 48)** *(proudly)* Look. Look at that thing swing. We hung an elephant today. An elephant. We made the impossible possible. This is America. And we can do anything we dream of. Anything at all!

HUNGRY TOWNSPERSON: **(Pg 50)** *(disgusted)* People go short mem'ries. But not me. *(beat)* All them colored boys led out to the yard must blur together somethin' fierce, 'ause nobody ever talk about how they hung colored boys in Erwin. They just talk about how they hung an elephant. Damndest thing. *(train whistle)*

RINGMASTER: **(Pg 52)** It was September and there was a Town and there was. Circus and there was a Man with Red Hair and there was an Elephant. (beat) You wait . . . After midnight, after the townsfolk have gone home and the prying eyes of Erwin are closed; sleeping with the certainty that their boogie monster is dead; You wake up the clowns and tell them to digger he up. Saw off her tusks and being them to you. You have to see what you can salvage, what you can get for the ivory. An elephant is an investment.

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Historical Reference material:
https://rarehistoricalphotos.com/murderous-mary-1916/

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